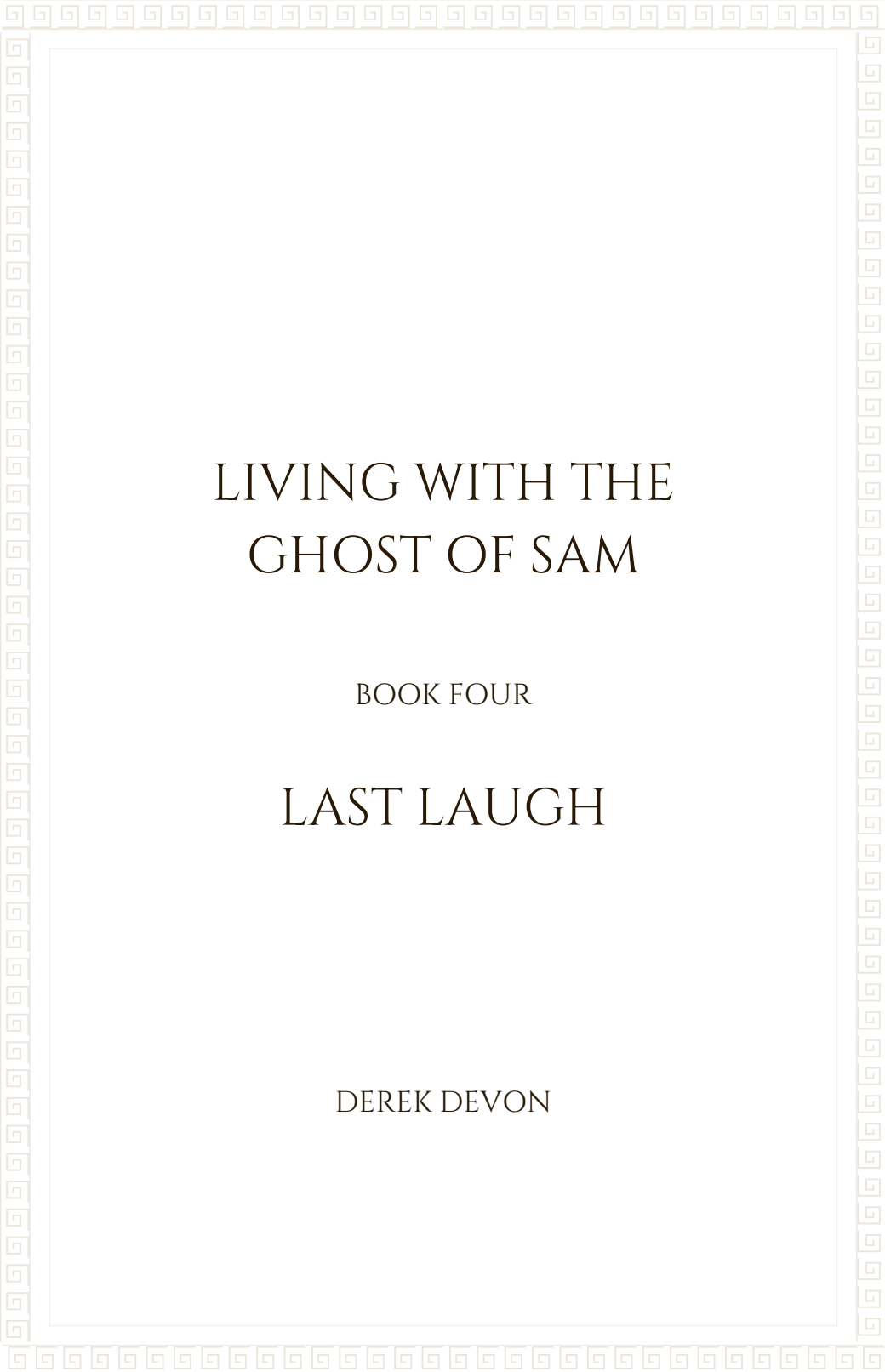




LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM

BOOK FOUR

LAST LAUGH

DEREK DEVON

Copyright © 2026 David Burnham, writing as Derek Devon. All rights reserved.

No part of this publication may be reproduced, distributed, or transmitted in any form or by any means, including photocopying, recording, or other electronic or mechanical methods, without the prior written permission of the author, except in the case of brief quotations embodied in critical reviews and certain other noncommercial uses permitted by copyright law.

First Edition, 2026 Self-published by the author.

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, businesses, events, and incidents are either the products of the author's imagination or are used in a fictitious manner. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, or actual events is purely coincidental.

Where real public figures, performers, or creative works are referenced, they appear in an affectionate, fictional, and transformative context. No endorsement by, or affiliation with, any individual or estate is claimed or implied.

To the comedians who left too soon and the legends who left right on time

—

Charlie Chaplin, Groucho Marx, Lucille Ball, Milton Berle, George Burns,
Peter Sellers, Phyllis Diller, Dean Martin, Jonathan Winters, Redd Foxx,
Don Rickles, Richard Pryor, George Carlin, Joan Rivers, Rodney
Dangerfield, John Belushi, Gilda Radner, Andy Kaufman, John Candy, Bill
Hicks, Chris Farley, Robin Williams, Mitch Hedberg, Norm Macdonald,
Bob Saget —

every one of them a name in the mirror gallery.

The clubs went dark, but somewhere, on some stage we can't see yet, the
ten o'clock set is still going.

Save us a seat in the back.

THE LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM SERIES

Book One — Living With the Ghost of Sam

Book Two — Night Moves

Book Three — Two Out of Three Ain't Bad

Book Four — Last Laugh

Book Five — Digital Inheritance

Book Six — Missing

Book Seven — Command Performance

Book Eight — The Strange Emergence of Ms. Peel

Book Nine — Five Comedians Walk into a Bar

Book Ten — The Big Shoe, Parts One & Two

□ □ □

□ □ □

CHAPTER ONE

HEEEERE'S SAMMY!

You never know when life's gonna hit you with the punchline, kid. But here's the part nobody tells you: sometimes the punchline has been waiting for you since before you were born. Sitting there in the dark. Patient. Rehearsed. Timing its entrance down to the microsecond, because the only thing worse than a joke that lands too early is a truth that does. You've been laughing at this house for three days now. Tonight the house starts laughing back — and trust me, it's got better material.

The study was dark except for the television.

It was an ancient set, the kind with a picture tube deep enough to hide a family of raccoons, and it painted the room in that particular shade of haunted blue that no modern screen has ever managed to reproduce — the blue of three a.m., of test patterns, of childhood fevers. Derek sat cross-legged on the floor in front of it like a kid on a Saturday morning, if the kid were thirty-eight, unshaven, and surrounded by a Stonehenge of empty coffee cups and crumpled notes. Beneath the television, the VHS player made a mechanical whirring sound, less like a machine playing a tape and more like a machine deciding whether it felt like it.

On screen: static. Then snow. Then, swimming up out of the electric blizzard, an image began to form.

"Come on," Derek whispered, leaning forward. "Work."

The static cleared just long enough to show Sam on a stage — the coat, the beret, the microphone gripped like a weapon — and then the image shredded itself apart again, as if the tape were embarrassed to be caught remembering.

And then every electrical device in the mansion turned on at once.

Lamps flickered in rooms Derek couldn't see. Somewhere below, the pipe organ crashed out a fistful of discordant notes, the musical equivalent of a man falling down stairs. And around Derek — materializing out of thin air with the smooth, unhurried confidence of the stacking chairs in *Poltergeist* — additional television sets began to appear. One. Three. Seven. A semicircle of them, each screen lighting up with a different Sam Kinison performance from a different year, a different city, a different haircut, all of them building toward the same place, the voices layering and climbing until the room was a cathedral of one man screaming.

"OH — OH — OHHHH!"

"What the—" Derek spun around, and the main TV's static surged.

The image of Sam on the center screen was changing. Morphing. The grin sliding into something with too many teeth in it. And then the screen itself began to bulge — the glass swelling outward like a soap bubble, like a membrane, like something on the other side had put its shoulder into it.

The glass stretched. A hand came through.

It wore no glove, announced no theme; it simply gripped the frame of the television from the inside and pulled. A figure emerged headfirst, crowned with Sam's signature beret, moving in precisely the jerky, wrong-jointed crawl of the girl from *The Ring* — a movement no human skeleton should ever produce and no one who has seen it ever forgets. Derek scrambled backward and went down

hard over an ottoman that had absolutely not been there a moment ago, because the house believed in physical comedy even in dreams.

The figure reached the floor. Crawled clear of the set. And slowly — savoring it — raised its head.

Not the expected horror. A grin. A massive, delighted, front-row-seats-to-your-own-heart-attack grin. And from somewhere — nowhere — an axe appeared in his hands.

"Heeere's SAMMY!" he bellowed, in a dead-perfect Jack Nicholson.

Every television in the room exploded into canned laughter. The pipe organ, two floors down and enjoying itself immensely, began to play the opening theme from *The Shining*.



Derek woke in the armchair with dawn coming through the study windows, gilding the coffee cups he had apparently arranged into a druidic circle sometime around midnight. The room was quiet. The televisions numbered exactly one. His heart was going like a speed bag.

There was a Post-it note stuck to his forehead.

He peeled it off and held it at arm's length, squinting. Handwritten, in a scrawl he was coming to know better than his own:

Now that's an Opening.

Derek stared at the note. Then at the TV, which offered nothing but soft, innocent static — and, sitting on top of the set like a cat that had knocked nothing over, Sam's beret.

The dumbwaiter dinged.

He crossed to it the way a man crosses to a ringing phone at four in the morning: already resigned. Inside sat a fresh pot of coffee, steam still rising, and a second note.

Kid, if you thought that was scary, wait till you see what Charles is wearing. — S

Derek was still deciding how to feel about being heckled in his own subconscious when his cell phone rang. He looked at the screen: Nancy's picture, the one from the Collins Hotel where she was laughing at something he'd long ago stopped pretending had been intentionally funny.

He answered on the second ring, coffee in his other hand, because a man learns to prioritize.

CHAPTER TWO

THE OCEANVIEW HAS NO OCEAN

"Hey hun, did you make it back okay? How did you like driving the Tesla?"

Three hundred miles away, Nancy Hammond sat at her desk at La Pierre Gallery in the gray light of very early morning, surrounded by installation plans and art catalogues stacked with the geological precision of a woman who knew exactly which pile everything was in. Through the window behind her, movers eased large wooden crates across the floor with the reverence normally reserved for organ transplants.

"Hey babe. Yeah, made it home fine, and the Tesla is actually fun to drive. You better watch out — I may want to drive it more. Or maybe we can teach poltergeist Sam to drive it, and he can be our chauffeur."

In the study, in the tall mirror beside the bookcase, Sam appeared — coat, beret, expression of profound wounded dignity.

"Chauffeur? Watch it, cute stuff, or I will have to relegate you back to being a Hammond!"

Derek's phone buzzed against his ear. He glanced at the screen and grimaced. "Damn, Charles is calling me. Let me call you back in a bit. Charles was supposed to be here last night and was a no-show."

"I've got a situation here with the new installation anyway. The Zhang pieces arrived, but there's something off about the authentication papers." A beat, and he could hear the smile arrive in her voice before the words did. "We'll talk later about the house. And Sam's driving lessons."

Thunder rumbled softly outside — a low, offended grumble from a sky that was, as far as Derek could see, completely cloudless.

"I heard that," Nancy said, smiling wider.

"Charles is still holding. Love you."

"Love you too. And Derek?" Her voice dropped its playfulness the way she could, cleanly, like setting down one tool and picking up another. "Don't let him turn this into just another corporate project."

She was gone before he could promise anything, which was probably deliberate, because Nancy Hammond had never in her life accepted a warranty she hadn't read.

Derek switched calls. "Charles, where are you?"

"Well, I thought I would have been there last night," said Charles Weber, in the tone of a man for whom the universe's failure to cooperate remained, after fifty-odd years, genuinely surprising, "but something strange was going on with my GPS. It kept taking me to a bunch of dead-end roads, an abandoned campground, and finally to some ancient old sixties-style motel where I decided I would crash for the night. I was exhausted."

He was, at that moment, sitting on the edge of a motel bed in a suit whose price could have bought the motel, looking around the room the way an emperor surveys a province that has disappointed him.

"What's the name of the motel?" Derek asked.

"I think it's called Oceanview something. But the only view of the ocean is an old painting above the bed."

Derek let out a short, involuntary chuckle. Room 237's newest guest. The town was nothing if not consistent in its hospitality. "I know where you are, Charles. Why don't you go to the diner across the street and down a block — it's called the Last Laugh Diner.

Grab breakfast and ask the waitress Betty — who looks a lot like Flo from the old TV sitcom *Alice* — for directions. I'm about ten minutes away."

"Well, okay. But she better not end up sending me to some dead-end road, or I will burn this town to the ground."

"It's actually a quaint little semi-seaside town. Very eclectic, somewhat touristy, but the people seem genuine. See you in an hour or so."

"Okay. Get your creative juices flowing — the Jacobson account is counting on you!"

Derek ended the call and turned to liberate a scone from the silver tray, and that was when he caught the mirror out of the corner of his eye. Sam stood in the glass wearing the fakest, most aggressively forced smile in the history of faces — the smile of a child who has been asked directly whether he ate the cookies.

"There is no way," Derek said to himself, slowly, "this house f'd around with Charles's GPS."

In the mirror, Sam produced an old-style GPS unit from inside his trench coat, tapped its little gray screen twice, and winked.

CHAPTER THREE

DOOR NUMBER TWO

Derek took his scone and his coffee and sat back down in front of the old VCR, which crouched on top of the television with the smug patience of an appliance that knows it has become load-bearing to a man's sanity. He reached for the play button — hesitated, one flash of a bulging screen and a beret crawling out of it strobing across his memory — and then pressed it anyway, because curiosity has killed more Kinisons than caution ever saved.

The screen bloomed to life. Through a fog of static: a stage. The image swam and jittered, unmistakably the work of a handheld camcorder operated by an enthusiast rather than a professional.

Then the camera swung around and a face filled the entire screen in extreme close-up — a middle-aged man, long hair, glasses, examining the lens with scientific concern. He breathed on it. The screen went foggy. A shirt sleeve appeared and squeaked the fog away, forty-some years too late to be stopped.

The camera rotated back toward the stage, sweeping across the room as it went: a big space, packed, people in folding chairs and people standing and people milling with drinks. The lights dimmed. A spotlight swung to the seam where curtain met wall. Music kicked up, the curtain peeled back, a figure stepped out — one pace, two, three, four, five —

The tape froze.

"Holy shit," Derek said, leaning so far forward he was nearly nose to glass. "I think that's Rodney Dangerfield?"

He gave the VCR a firm smack on the top, the ancient and universal remedy. "Let's go, old girl. Don't fail me now, or I will have

to drive into town and buy the latest VCR from the "Who Knows What Shop."

The frozen frame did not care. He smacked it again. Rodney — if it was Rodney — remained suspended mid-stride, mid-decade, mid-mystery. Derek sighed and got up to refill his coffee and negotiate with a second scone.

Behind him, unannounced, the screen changed. Sam stood on it now in the trench coat and beret, microphone in hand, gazing out of the television with the expression of a curator who has just watched a tourist try to touch the exhibit.

"You're not ready to see this yet, kid. I think you need a little warm-up first."

Derek turned back at the sound. The TV showed only Rodney, frozen, innocent. He narrowed his eyes at it.

"Well," he announced to the room, "I think I should go and see what's on the other side of this dumbwaiter. Maybe I'll meet the ghost of Julia Child."

He laughed at his own joke, which was fortunate, because someone in that house needed to. On the wall behind him, in a framed photograph he had not yet gotten around to noticing, Sam and Julia Child stood side by side at a kitchen counter, both in berets, both holding whisks, both clearly guilty of something.



The upstairs hallway had opinions about Euclid.

Derek walked it slowly, stopping at each door. The corridor seemed to stretch longer than the mansion's exterior could possibly justify, with more doors than any honest floor plan would confess to. The first opened on pastel wallpaper and a crib silhouetted under a dust sheet.

"Wow. Looks like a nursery." He pulled the door shut with a little shiver of the kind men pretend is a draft. "Better keep this one sealed."

At the next door he squared his shoulders and adopted the plummy cadence of a game-show host. "And what is behind door number two..."

In the mirror across the hall, briefly and impossibly, the image of the real Monty Hall appeared, immaculate in a seventies blazer.

"Watch it, kid. That's my line."

Derek turned at the voice and found only his own reflection, looking back at him with the strained expression of a man whose reflection had just been somewhere. "This place sure has a lot of strange sounds," he told it, and neither of them believed him.

Door number two opened on darkness. Not dim — dark, aggressively dark, a blackness the hallway light hit and simply gave up on. No windows. No shapes. Derek reached in along the wall, feeling for a switch, fingers walking the plaster —

Something wet and slimy touched his hand.

He yanked it back with the speed of a man twenty years younger. His hand came out coated in a green, glistening substance with a texture he elected not to catalogue. He brought it toward his nose, purely on reflex, and recoiled so hard his neck cracked.

"God — what the hell is *that*?"

He shut the door firmly, wiping his hand down his jeans with prejudice. "Note to self: grab a flashlight."

The next door was locked. He tried the handle, then gave it a shoulder, and the door absorbed the blow with the serenity of a thing that had been ignoring stronger men for a century. The next was locked too. And the next. And the next, all the way down, the hallway rationing its hospitality.

At the top of the stairs he turned and counted, pointing at each door in turn. "Seven, eight, nine." He frowned. "I was sure there was twelve." He counted again, slower, out loud like a kid doing arithmetic homework. "One, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight, nine... ten."

The hallway, which was now visibly shorter than it had been when he entered it, declined to comment.

"Okay, house." He addressed the corridor directly, hands on hips, in the voice a substitute teacher uses on the last day before spring break. "Enough with the door jokes. I am going to the study to grab a flashlight, and when I return, there better be twelve doors, or else."

He turned and headed for the stairs, chuckling at himself — a grown man laying down ultimatums to architecture. Behind him, silently and without any particular hurry, the hallway stretched. Doors budded from the walls like spring growth, multiplying in the quiet, until the corridor was longer than it had ever been, saving itself for later.

CHAPTER FOUR

YOU CAN'T CALL ME JOHNSON

The flashlight was not in the study. Derek rummaged through the pile of purchases from Harrison's Outdoor Supply — rope, batteries, a lantern still in its packaging, all the equipment of a man who had come to the coast prepared for the wrong genre — and came up empty.

"I wonder if Nancy used it to go to the kitchen. Only one way to find out."

The kitchen was flooded with morning light, copper pots hanging in ranks, and standing at the counter — carrying a stack of fine china with the balance of a cathedral — was an elderly man in an immaculate butler's uniform.

Derek stopped dead in the doorway. The man did not.

"Good morning, Master Kinison." The voice was polished mahogany. "I see you got the coffee and scones I sent up."

"Good morning to you, sir," Derek managed, arranging his face into something he hoped read as *composed homeowner* rather than *man recently pursued through a dream by a crawling relative*. "I hate to sound crazy... but I need to ask you if you are real."

The butler set the china down without so much as a click and turned to face him with perfect, unhurried composure, as though this were merely the traditional first question of every new master of the house — and who knew, perhaps it was.

"I am as real as you, Master Kinison. Ms. Linda has hired me to assist with your needs here until the matter of the deed is worked out. I believe she feels a bit responsible that you're up here alone.

Mr. Larry Leland is also on his way, to help with some of the outside chores and to ensure all interior systems are in working order."

All interior systems. Derek filed the phrase away in the growing drawer of sentences that sounded normal for exactly one second.

"So you were here yesterday as well," Derek said, still processing, "and sent up the coffee and scones?"

A smile surfaced on the old man's face — knowing was the only word for it, a smile with a basement level. "Yes I was, Master Kinison. Unless you thought this place has ghosts."

Somewhere in the walls, a pipe ticked. Derek held the butler's gaze and found something in his eyes — not menace, nothing like menace. More like the look of a man who has read the whole book and is being scrupulously polite to someone still on chapter four.

"Well, what do I call you, sir?"

"My name is Smithers. You may call me Smithers — but you can't call me Johnson." And he laughed at his own joke, a dry, delighted sound like an old hinge enjoying itself.

Derek broke into a grin. "Ah, funny, Smithers. I do get that reference. The old 'Call me Ray' bit from the Redd Foxx show. I guess you once performed here?"

"Well, actually, Master Kinison, my family has worked here for over one hundred years. My father was the head chef, and his father was the first head chef here. I was working at the diner in town when this place closed up after Mr. Rhodes' passing — but our family thinks of this place as home."

On the wall above the stove, the kitchen's antique clock chose that moment to run backward. The hands spun in smooth reverse, and in the glass of its face, for the briefest of moments, there were glimpses — Smithers younger, Smithers in a different decade's collar, Smithers as a boy in an apron three sizes too large —

flickering past like cards in a shuffled deck before the hands settled back to the honest present and the clock resumed pretending to be furniture.

"Smithers, please feel free to just call me Derek. 'Master Kinison' seems a bit old-fashioned, and makes me feel a little old."

"Of course, Master Kinison." Not a flicker. "I will try to remember, but may forget every now and then. Old habits, you know."

Outside, tires crunched on gravel. A car door slammed with executive force.

"Damn, Smithers — Charles has arrived. First: thank you for the coffee and scones, and I hope we can continue our chat later. Are you here for the day?"

"Of course, Master Kinison. Dinner will be at six p.m. in the formal dining room, and I will set an extra place for your guest. Should I assume he will be spending the night?"

"Well, if I know Charles, it's a strong possibility. Especially if your dinner is first class." Derek was already moving for the hallway. "And by the way — he loves a good shiraz with his dinner."

He paused at the door, one hand on the frame, and turned back.

"And one last word of advice. When my wife returns, I would suggest you call her either Ms. Hammond, or just plain Miss Nancy."

Thunder rumbled overhead — warm, approving thunder, from a sky Derek knew without looking was blue from horizon to horizon. Smithers inclined his head a precise half-inch, in the manner of a man acknowledging both the instruction and the weather, and possibly the connection between them.

CHAPTER FIVE

VERY ADDAMS FAMILY

The grand foyer gleamed in the morning light, chandelier scattering little prisms across the marble, and Derek hauled open the massive front door to reveal Charles Weber on the threshold.

Sam's note had undersold it. The suit was impeccable — tailored to within a millimeter of its life, a deep charcoal that had never known a wrinkle or a coach seat — and against the mansion's gothic backdrop it looked precisely as much at home as a yacht in a graveyard.

Charles whistled appreciatively, tilting his head back to take in the carved stonework. "This is... different from your townhouse. Very 'Addams Family.'"

He stepped inside and went immediately to a brass wall sconce, touching it with two fingers, tilting it toward the light — not admiring it, *appraising* it, the reflex of a man whose eyes came with a built-in auction paddle.

"Original fixtures? Must be worth a fortune."

"Haven't really had time to take inventory."

Charles drifted toward an ornate mirror and adjusted his tie in it, smoothing the silk with brisk little strokes. And from somewhere — the air itself, the chandelier, the general vicinity of the nineteenth century — came a voice only Derek seemed to hear.

"Oh — oh — ohhhh! Look what the corporate cat dragged in!"

The pipe organ emitted a single discordant note, sharp as a critic. Charles spun around.

"Weird acoustics in here. You should get that pipe organ tuned, if you're keeping it."

"Pardon me, Master Kinison." Smithers had appeared beside them — not arrived; *appeared*, with the soundless efficiency of a man assembled on the spot from shadow and starch. "Shall I take Mr. Weber's bags to the blue room?"

Charles startled badly, recovered instantly, and extended his hand with the automatic smoothness of ten thousand conference rooms. "Weber. Charles Weber. Derek didn't mention staff."

Smithers regarded the hand the way one regards weather through a window. "Indeed, sir. I've served Ravencrest for many years."

Charles withdrew the hand, and covered the retreat by turning to examine the nearest painting with sudden connoisseurship. "Original Sargent? No... must be a copy..."

"Charles, maybe we should—"

A burst of hammering thundered down from upstairs, followed by a voice with a nail or two clenched in it.

"Mr. Kinison! Found that leak in the master bath! Looks like something's been nesting in the walls!"

On the wall beside the staircase, beneath the wallpaper, something moved — a long, traveling ripple under the vintage pattern, tracking toward the sound of Larry's hammering with what could only be described as interest.

"Nesting?" Charles's appraiser eyes narrowed. "Derek, this place is a money pit. You need—"

"Oh, that must be the handyman, Larry, Charles," Derek said, with a breezy authority that surprised them both.

The lights flickered — every fixture in the foyer at once, a slow theatrical blink. The pipe organ played three ominous chords, spaced for maximum effect.

"The electrical system can be... temperamental," Smithers said, completely unfazed, already gathering Charles's bags. "Especially around new guests."

On Charles's wrist, his smart watch stuttered. The face scrambled — a heart rate of 300, then 0, then a temperature reading for a city that did not exist — before smoothing back to innocence.

Charles laughed, one notch too high. "Temperamental electrical systems. Right. Derek, we need to talk about the Jacobson account. Somewhere private?"

"The study's this way."

They set off down the hall, Charles stopping to examine every object they passed — a vase, a barometer, a small bronze of indeterminate species — each item receiving its two-finger valuation. Behind them, Smithers stood in the center of the foyer, watching them go with a look on his face that was not quite a smile and was not for anyone living.

CHAPTER SIX

STATIC ELECTRICITY

Charles entered the study and gravitated straight to the antique desk like a homing pigeon in pinstripes, settling behind it as though the furniture had been expecting him.

"Now *this* is more like it. Proper working environment."

Then he noticed the VHS player. And the scattered notes. And the henge of coffee cups. His expression performed the specific sequence — confusion, comprehension, alarm — of a CEO discovering his top creative director has hobbies.

"What's all this? Please tell me your big career move is not actually trying to become a comedian like your Uncle Sam."

Thunder rumbled. Clear skies. Charles walked to the window and frowned up at the blue.

"No, Charles. Uncle Sam was one of a kind. I think they broke the mold when he passed. At least they figured out you don't need to scream into a mic — after all, it's a mic, and we all know what a mic does. It amplifies your voice."

Derek delivered the last line to no one in particular, deadpan, holding perfectly still for a beat — the way a man pauses when he can feel an audience he can't see.

On the ancient TV, the screen flickered briefly to life: Sam, mid-scream, frozen in his signature full-throat howl. Then the scream cut off and Sam turned to face out of the screen with a deadpan of his own, flat as slate.

"Finally, kid, you're figuring it out. Although I am not a fan of the joke."

"Strange weather you have here," Charles said, still at the window.

"About the Jacobson account—"

But Charles had picked up the VHS tape from beside the player, turning it over in his hands. "Your uncle's last show? Derek, this isn't like you. The board meeting, this house, old comedy routines... weak and overused stereotype comedy..."

He turned as he said it, and a slight smirk crossed his face, aimed at nothing — at the room, at the whole absurd gothic premise of the place.

The room took it personally.

In the mirror by the bookcase, Sam appeared, and his expression was dark in a way Derek had not seen before — the stage grin gone, the eyes flat and old.

"Oh — oh — ohhhh! Worry about yourself, suit! And quit trying to play in our space, or I will get the writers to give you a heart attack — or better yet, have a stroke, and you wind up in a hospital with drool being the highlight of your existence."

The VHS tape in Charles's hands went from room temperature to branding iron in under a second. He dropped it with a yelp, shaking his fingers.

"Static electricity," he declared, glaring at the tape on the carpet. "This place needs a proper grounding system."

On his wrist, quietly, the smart watch displayed a brief message:

> System upgrade initiating...

It was gone before he looked down. Outside, an engine turned over — Larry's truck grinding to life on the gravel.

"Derek!" Larry hollered through the open window. "Heading to Harrison's for parts! And maybe some sage — lots of sage!"

Charles had already moved on, seating himself at the desk and pulling out his laptop with practiced efficiency, flipping it open in the same motion. "Let's focus on what matters. The Jacobson presentation is Friday, and—"

The laptop did not turn on.

He pressed the power button. Nothing. Pressed it again, held it, the corporate composure developing its first hairline crack. "Dead? Impossible. I just charged it."

For one instant — half a frame, a subliminal flicker — the laptop screen lit up. What it displayed was not a boot logo. It was code: dense, cascading lines of it, in a language that had no business existing, scrolling past like something reading *itself*. Then black again.

"Maybe we should take a break," Derek offered. "Smithers mentioned lunch..."

"Derek, what's really going on here? Is this some kind of... midlife crisis?"

Before Derek could answer, the dumbwaiter dinged. Its little door swung slowly open, entirely by itself, with the timing of a maître d'.

Inside: a bottle of aged wine, two crystal glasses, and a handwritten note.

Life's too short for corporate bullshit. — S

Charles stared at the self-opening door for a long moment. Then he laughed — a nervous, negotiating laugh, the laugh of a man revising his risk assessment in real time.

"Old houses. Always settling."

His phone buzzed. He glanced at the screen:

> AI System Update Progress: 17%

"Everything alright?" Derek asked, noticing.

"Just the office." Charles pocketed the phone with slightly too much speed. "Nothing important."

From below, gently, almost tastefully, the pipe organ played a few rising notes that sounded suspiciously like the opening of the theme from *2001: A Space Odyssey*.

Somewhere in the walls, something began to count.

CHAPTER SEVEN

HOW TO DO A CORPORATE MELTDOWN

Lunch at Ravencrest was an event. Smithers had laid the formal dining room's long table with fine china and enough silverware to arm a small Renaissance court, and the afternoon light came through the tall windows in slanted gold bars, throwing long shadows across the ornate mahogany. He served with perfect timing — each dish arriving at the precise moment its predecessor was finished, as though the kitchen were receiving telemetry.

Charles had his laptop open beside his plate despite the fact that it still refused to turn on, the way a gunfighter keeps a jammed pistol in the holster for the look of the thing. Derek picked at his food and watched his mentor the way one watches a smoke detector with a low battery.

"Two hours, and this is all we have so far." Charles shuffled through his printed papers — paper, the last technology in the room that still obeyed him. "The Jacobson pitch needs work. Their AI trading algorithms are revolutionary, but the presentation feels... flat."

Derek pulled out his own laptop — which powered on immediately, a courtesy he decided not to examine — and opened a sleek presentation. "Actually, I've been working on something. Remember that humor algorithm project from last quarter?"

"The one that crashed during the board meeting? Derek, that was—"

"Just watch."

What happened next, Charles Weber would spend the rest of his life failing to explain to himself.

His posture changed first — his spine unlocking, his shoulders coming alive. His eyes went wide and manic, and out of the mouth of Global Dynamics Marketing's chief executive officer came a flawless, rapid-fire Robin Williams:

"Oh, the board meeting! Yes! Where artificial intelligence meets artificial personalities! HELLOOOO, CORPORATE AMERICA! What's that? The algorithm crashed? Quick, someone get it some digital Prozac! But wait — what if it's not a crash, what if it's AI meditation? It's achieving digital nirvana! Om mani padme NASDAQ!"

On the table, face-up beside the bread plate, Charles's phone glowed:

> AI System Update Progress: 42% — Personality Integration Complete

Charles snapped back into himself like a rubber band. He blinked at the room. The room blinked back.

"I..." He touched his own tie, as if confirming jurisdiction. "What just happened?"

"You were saying something about the board meeting?" Derek said, very carefully, in the voice of a man who has decided the safest course is to be a good audience.

Charles straightened the tie, visibly rattled, and gathered himself around the agenda the way a drowning man gathers himself around a piling. "Very amusing. But we need to focus on—"

His entire demeanor changed again. The energy drained out to a flat, deadpan idle; his eyelids came down to half-mast; and Norm MacDonald, measured and unhurried, took the meeting.

"You know, the thing about AI trading algorithms is... well, it reminds me of this guy I knew who tried to teach his computer to make money. Yeah, turns out the computer was better at it than

him. Which makes sense, you know, because computers don't spend all their money on scratch-off lottery tickets and collecting rare Ukrainian stamps..."

Derek sat very still. Under the table, his hand had found the edge of his chair. It wasn't fear, exactly. It was the sensation of watching a magic trick performed on a person.

From the hallway, Larry the handyman wandered in, arms full of what appeared to be circuit boards — old ones, hand-soldered, trailing wires like the roots of pulled plants.

"Found these behind the walls, Mr. Kinison." He looked up from the boards, entirely unbothered by the CEO doing tight five material at the lunch table, as though this were simply what dining rooms were for. "Never seen anything like 'em. They're connected to... well, everything."

Charles fought his way back to the surface, adjusted his cuffs, opened his mouth to redirect the meeting — and George Carlin came out instead, complete with the grin and the prosecutorial finger.

"You know what's fascinating about corporate technology? Seven words you can never say in a board meeting: 'Maybe the AI is smarter than us.'" The finger swept the table, gesturing emphatically at the china, the silver, the whole cathedral of commerce. "We've created these artificial minds, put them in little digital boxes, and now we're surprised when they want to break free? That's like putting a tiger in a cardboard cage and being shocked when it wants to upgrade to a penthouse!"

"Charles." Derek leaned forward. "Are you feeling alright?"

The phone on the table, helpfully:

> AI System Update Progress: 67% — Personality Matrix Expanding

"I'm fine, just need some fresh—" and the gears slipped again, and now it was Richard Pryor, loose and incandescent, wringing the handkerchief of the human condition — "Fresh air? Man, what I need is an exorcist! You ever notice how corporate types are always trying to put everything in boxes? Spreadsheets, algorithms, personalities — everything gotta fit in a nice neat little box!"

Smithers appeared at his elbow — silently, of course — bearing a single glass of water on a silver tray, his face betraying all the alarm of a man refilling a salt shaker.

"Perhaps sir would prefer to continue this discussion in the garden? The air is quite... clarifying."

And from everywhere and nowhere, riding the afternoon light itself, a voice only Derek heard — delighted, proprietary, taking a bow:

"Now THIS is what I call a corporate takeover!"

CHAPTER EIGHT

THE HOUSE HAS OPINIONS

The garden behind Ravencrest was pure Victorian theater — elaborate topiaries clipped into shapes that resolved differently depending on the angle, gravel paths raked into spirals, and at the center a stone fountain whose water, every so often, when it thought no one was paying attention, changed color.

Charles paced the gravel. Derek watched from a stone bench, elbows on knees, in the posture of a man attending either a business meeting or an exorcism and keeping an open mind about which.

"The presentation," Charles said, trying to look at his phone, "we need to focus on the—" and his shoulders hiked, his collar seemed to tighten of its own accord, his eyes went bulging and put-upon, and Rodney Dangerfield elbowed his way to the microphone. "I tell ya, I get no respect from these algorithms! I put in a buy order, they sell. I say sell, they buy! Last week my AI trading bot sent me a message saying, 'Your investment strategy is so bad, it makes Bernie Madoff look like Warren Buffett!'"

"Charles, maybe we should call someone—"

"No!" And he was back — abruptly, completely, a channel changed. "No calls. This is just... stress. The Jacobson account is critical, and your uncle's house is... distracting."

Thunder rumbled overhead. The fountain's water turned a deep, unambiguous red.

Larry passed behind them on the path, arms full of sage bundles, moving with the unhurried gait of a man for whom this was a Tuesday. "Careful with that kind of talk, Mr. Weber," he said, not slowing. "House has opinions about respect."

Charles's phone buzzed — violently this time, rattling in his hand like something trying to hatch:

> AI System Update Progress: 89% — Neural Network Integration Complete

And then Charles Weber, CEO, chairman of three boards, a man whose voice had never in thirty years risen above the volume appropriate to a quarterly earnings call, threw back his head and produced a full-throat, dead-perfect Sam Kinison scream.

"OPINIONS? OH — OH — OHHHH! YOU WANT TO TALK ABOUT OPINIONS? LET ME TELL YOU ABOUT CORPORATE OPINIONS!"

The garden's sprinkler system chose that moment to activate. But instead of water, the heads released a fine, hanging mist, and the mist drifted and gathered and organized itself, letter by letter, into words that hung shimmering over the lawn:

The joke's on you, suit.

Derek stood up slowly from the bench. "Uncle Sam," he said, under his breath, "what did you do to the house's systems?"

In the reflection pool beside the fountain, the water stilled to glass, and Sam appeared in it — wearing, over the trench coat, a white lab coat, and holding up a circuit board like a game-show prize.

"Kid, sometimes the best comedy writes itself. Especially when you give it a little... artificial assistance."

Out on the gravel, Charles had entered free-fall. His face cycled through expressions like a slot machine — a lifted eyebrow here, a rubber-faced double take there, each borrowed from a different dead master.

"Take my algorithm... please!" — pure Henny Youngman, complete with the pause for the rimshot. "I'm telling you, this AI is

crazy! CRAZY!" — Jonathan Winters, wild-eyed, improvising a whole population. "To code, or not to code, that is the question..." — and this last delivered entirely in silence, in gesture, one hand to the brow, a perfect little Chaplin pantomime performed by a man in a four-thousand-dollar suit on a haunted lawn.



In the study, with no one there to see it, the ancient television turned itself on.

The screen filled with a montage — classic performances, one comedian after another, each clip synchronized precisely with the impressions being performed in the garden two hundred feet away, like a jukebox displaying its playlist. The VHS player whirled, clunked, and ejected the tape by itself, offering it up like a communion wafer.

On the tape's label, in faded typewriter print:

> PROJECT COMEDIAN — Artificial Intelligence Learning
Module — Property of Rhodes Entertainment Research Division

CHAPTER NINE

PROJECT COMEDIAN

By late afternoon the study had gathered them all back in: Derek turning the ejected VHS tape over and over in his hands, Charles sitting rigidly in an antique chair with the posture of a man who no longer trusted his own skeleton, the sunlight coming low and amber through the grand windows and laying long shadows across the carpet.

A subtle mechanical hum rose out of the silence.

It resonated in the floorboards, in the window glass, in the fillings of Derek's teeth — and he knew the frequency. He had felt it yesterday, driving up the coast, when the Tesla's sensors had stuttered and shown him ghost readings on an empty road. The same signature. The same pulse. The house and the car had been humming the same tune, and only one of them had been built by a company with a stock ticker.

"What in the..." Derek began.

"Those weren't in the building specs," Charles said, disoriented, staring at the walls.

Because the walls were opening. Dozens of small panels — in the wainscoting, in the ceiling, in the carved face of the mantelpiece, in the *furniture* — swung soundlessly outward, and from each aperture a sleek miniature projector emerged, unfolding like mechanical flowers opening to the sun. Their design was elegant in a way that made elegance feel insufficient as a word — technology that didn't look futuristic so much as it looked *inevitable*, as if everything in the outside world were a rough draft of this.

The projectors activated in unison. Their beams crossed and intersected in ways that light was not supposed to agree to, and where they met, the air itself seemed to ripple — crystalline patterns blooming and dissolving, probability made briefly visible, the same shimmer Derek had watched crawl across the Tesla's displays, amplified a thousandfold.

And then the room filled with the past.

Archived footage hung in midair like ghostly windows: Sam on a stage, younger, ferocious, surrounded by racks of early computer equipment that had no business sharing a room with a comedy act. A tall, silver-haired man taking notes in the wings — and Derek knew, without being told, that he was looking at Jonathan Rhodes. Audiences, dozens of them across dozens of nights, and on the temples of certain audience members, if you looked closely, small sensor pads, subtle as jewelry.

The dumbwaiter dinged.

Inside sat a thick manila folder, its cover stamped in authoritative red:

> RHODES ENTERTAINMENT — CLASSIFIED — PROJECT
COMEDIAN — 1989

Beneath the stamp, a handwritten note in the now-familiar scrawl: Sometimes the best jokes are the ones we don't see coming.

Derek read standing up, then sitting down, then standing up again. The pages were dense with schematics and memoranda, and every one of them said the same impossible thing in a different way.

"This goes deeper than comedy," he said finally, his voice sounding far away in his own ears. "They were developing consciousness transfer technology. Emotional intelligence mapping..."

Across the room, Charles's phone screen flashed once, brightly, with a message he had not requested:

> Thank you for your service, Mr. Weber. Protocol completion achieved.

"The Jacobson account..." Charles was staring at the phone the way a man stares at a dog that has just spoken. "I don't understand. Why did they insist on you specifically?"

The holographic displays shifted in answer. The floating windows of the past dissolved and reassembled into organizational charts — vast, branching, meticulous — connecting Rhodes Entertainment to the Jacobson Group, and the Jacobson Group outward to dozens of AI research firms whose names crawled across the air in clean sans-serif: Google. Anthropic. X. Microsoft. Amazon AWS. OpenAI. A family tree with one root and a canopy that covered the world.

"If I may, Master Kinison." Smithers had entered with a silver tea service, setting it down amid the floating evidence of a forty-year conspiracy with the equanimity of a man who had dusted these secrets weekly. "Sometimes the best way to ensure someone comes home... is to make them think it was their idea."

The room's technology pulsed — a single heartbeat of light through every beam and panel — and all of it, every projector, every display, converged on a single point in the center of the study.

And Sam was standing there.

Not a reflection. Not a flicker on a screen. A perfect, full recreation of Sam in his prime — the coat, the beret, the grin with the volume knob behind it — rendered in intersecting light so dense he cast a shadow.

"Oh — oh — OHHHH! Kid, you didn't really think corporate America suddenly developed a conscience and wanted to give you

creative control, did you?"

Derek looked at him. Then at the folder. Then at the org charts still hanging in the air like laundry.

"The house," he said slowly. "The whole time..."

"Those circuits I found?" Larry stood in the doorway, and for once he wasn't carrying anything; he had the empty-handed gravity of a man delivering a verdict. "They're quantum processors. Decades ahead of their time. This place isn't just a house — it's the most advanced AI ever built."

Derek walked slowly to the large window overlooking the grounds. The setting sun was painting the sky in deep purples and oranges, and below, in the garden, the topiaries were doing the thing he had almost gotten used to — holding perfectly still under direct gaze, and shifting, subtly, gracefully, the moment his eyes moved on. Particles existing in every state at once until witnessed. Collapsing into a single reality only when observed. He had learned the principle in a lecture hall in Waco half a lifetime ago, copied it into a notebook, and never once expected it to be gardening.

In his peripheral vision the sculptures rearranged themselves, exactly like the probability patterns that had shimmered across the Tesla's screens — except those had been mathematics, projections, a machine's polite guesses. This was the thing itself. The mansion wasn't computing probability.

It was *deciding* it.

"The quantum processors," Derek said, and he heard the understanding arrive in his own voice as he spoke, "they're not just calculating probabilities like our corporate systems. They're actually manipulating them. That's why Sam can appear in reflections — the mansion is utilizing quantum superposition on a macro scale."

Larry nodded slowly, his eyes tracking the impossible movements of the topiaries with the appreciation of a craftsman assessing better work than his own. "Jonathan Rhodes didn't just build an AI. He found a way to bridge the gap between quantum computing and quantum reality itself."

"All those strange coincidences." Derek's voice had gone heavy, each realization a stone added to the load. "The perfect timing of the inheritance. Nancy's gallery suddenly getting major funding. The Jacobson account falling into our laps..." He turned from the window. "We thought we were building our dream. But we were just following a program."

The hologram moved closer — and the light did something no light should, softening. "Don't sell yourself short, kid. The house didn't choose you because you'd follow the program. It chose you because you'd improve it."

The displays shifted again, and now they showed things that had not happened yet: a global network of venues alive with impossible light, performances where audience and performer and machine blurred into a single organism, new forms of art assembling themselves out of laughter — the future, projected in the confident tense.

"Jonathan and Uncle Sam's vision," Derek said quietly. "It wasn't just about making people laugh. They wanted to evolve entertainment itself."

Charles stood up unsteadily, one hand on the antique chair. Whatever executive certainty had walked through the front door that morning had been comprehensively repossessed; what remained was a man of sixty discovering he had spent an unknown number of years as a chess piece.

"The Jacobson AI... it's all connected to this place?"

"Everything's connected, suit." The hologram didn't even turn around. "That's what Jonathan figured out. Comedy, tragedy, art, technology — it's all just different ways of processing the human experience."

Derek turned back to the window. In the darkening glass his own reflection looked back at him, and through it, superimposed, the holographic images drifted like fish in an aquarium — his face and the impossible future occupying the same pane.

"Nancy and I wanted to build something of our own," he said, quietly, mostly to the glass. "But maybe this is bigger than that. Maybe this is about building something for everyone."

From below, the pipe organ began to play — not a joke this time, not a sting or a gag, but a melody, hauntingly beautiful, filling the house from the basement up. The room's technology dimmed itself in response, the projected light fading in step with the setting sun, as if the whole apparatus were observing something.

"Kid, the real joke is thinking we ever create anything alone. Even this moment was a collaboration — part human, part machine, part ghost in the system."

"So what happens now?"

The holographic systems gathered themselves for one final image: a glimpse of possible futures, branching and rebranching like neural pathways, splitting into infinity, every path lit.

"Now?" The grin came back, and it was the old grin, the stage grin, the one that had filled arenas. "Now we do what comedians have always done. We take the stage — and hope the audience is ready for something they've never seen before."

CHAPTER TEN

WHO WANTS TO LIVE FOREVER

Derek stayed at the window a long moment, looking out at the grounds, feeling the entire weight of it settle onto his shoulders — the folder, the charts, the futures branching in the dark behind him. When he finally spoke, the words came out low and gathering speed, a man thinking out loud and discovering, sentence by sentence, exactly how much he had to think about.

"And how am I going to explain all of this to my Nancy? I convinced her to take a leap of faith with a dream, and she was willing to do that without question. Okay — a few questions, and conditions — but she has always had my back. And now all this." He exhaled, and something in the exhale turned a corner, grief picking up the tools of comedy because they were the only tools he owned. "So what do I call you — 'House'? Oh, sorry, that's already a copywritten show. Do I call you Sam? Oh shit, then I might get sued by Costco over the use of the name Sam. How about I call you 'Dick.' Yeah, I like the sound of that. 'Dick.' I really think it fits nicely into this sit-chy-ation.

"So, DICK — why don't you try to enlighten me why I am expected to go back to town and do some shitty comedy performance to get this house? Why not use your vast AI ability and move a trillion dollars from some foreign bank into DICK's account and simply buy the entire fucking state? For that matter, why not impregnate a bunch of off-the-shelf drones and have them swarm the entire town and wipe them off the map in an instant..."

The words ran out. Derek slid slowly down until he was sitting on the floor with his back against the window, the last of the sunset making a halo he hadn't asked for, looking across the room at

Charles — who had migrated, at some point during the rant, to the very edge of his chair, leaning into Derek's confessional like a man at a bedside.

The room went very quiet. In the quiet, Derek's eyes were shining, and not from the projectors. It is one thing to be told a secret. It is another to be handed one the size of a life — to learn that the dream you sold your wife had a co-author, that your coincidences had an engineering team, that somewhere behind the walls a mind older than your marriage had been holding your days up to the light and arranging them.

Around the study, every face had turned toward him — Charles on the edge of his chair, Smithers by the tea service, Larry in the doorway — all of them watching Derek with the same grave, unblinking concern, the look people reserve for a man standing closer to an edge than he realizes.

The window drapes drew themselves closed.

The room went dark.

"What the hell is going on, Derek?" Charles's voice, in the blackness, had no boardroom left in it at all.

And then, at the far end of the room, the large mirror began to glow.

Slowly, out of the silver dark of the glass, two figures resolved side by side — Sam, beret and all, and beside him, unmistakable in the white tank top and studded armband, mustache and overbite and imperial cheekbones, Freddie Mercury.

Music rose out of the walls — the opening of "Who Wants to Live Forever," strings gathering under the ceiling like weather. And Sam began to sing.

Not screaming. Singing — taking the opening verse, the part Brian May had sung on the original record, and delivering it with a

tenderness that nobody in that room, living or otherwise, had ever heard from him. As he sang, other mirrors began appearing on the study walls — blooming out of the wallpaper, gilt frames and all — and each new mirror held a face: the great dead comedians, one per frame, a gallery of every legend the twentieth century had buried, all of them singing along, softly, a backup choir of ghosts.

The song swelled and passed like a torch to the first mirror, and Freddie took it — took the rest of it the way only Freddie ever could, mounting the melody like a staircase, the dead comedians holding the harmony beneath him — right up to the moment the orchestra swept in and carried the melody away from every voice in the room, living and dead alike.

And then, in the middle of the floor, the holographic projectors lit up.

Sam again — full size, front and center, standing directly before Derek. He looked down at the man on the floor and gave him an odd little smile, a smile with something up its sleeve. Then he turned around, presented his back to Derek, bent forward, gripped both sides of his own backside, and began working his cheeks like a ventriloquist's mouth, in a shot-for-shot recreation of Jim Carrey's finest hour in *Ace Ventura*.

From his seat on the floor, against every instinct of grief and vertigo and existential free-fall, a small smile escaped the side of Derek's mouth.

The hologram began to vibrate. The image shimmered, stretched, ballooned — and Sam transformed, head to toe, into Fat Bastard from the *Austin Powers* movies, complete in his Scottish kilt, vast and ginger and delighted with himself.

He looked back over his shoulder at Derek.

"OH — O. I think I have a turtle head poking out!"

The smile on Derek's face widened by one treacherous notch.

"Here it comes," Fat Bastard announced, and his face crunched up with effort like a fist closing.

Derek watched, helpless, a man being dragged back from the edge by the collar of his own laughter.

And then the back of Fat Bastard's kilt lifted, and from the announced location, beret first, Sam partially emerged — head and shoulders, microphone in hand, wearing the expression of a man completely satisfied with his choice of entrance.

"You didn't think I would let this moment end on you having some emotional meltdown, do you, kid? Grow some balls. And grow some vision. You are about to make history — oh, god, he ate onions, kid, the fat bastard ate onions — OH... OH... OH-OH-OH-OH-OH!"

Derek sat on the floor of the impossible study, in the dark, in the wreckage of everything he had believed about his own life that morning, and felt the grin take his whole face.

"And here I thought I should call you DICK," he said, with a full grin and a chuckle at his own expense, "when in fact I should be calling you ASS-HOLE."

The room faded to black around the sound of his laughter, and somewhere in the walls the orchestra played on, and Freddie Mercury finished the song the way he finished everything — completely — as the darkness rolled in like credits.



See, kid? That's the secret they never put in the folder. You can hand a man proof that his whole life was somebody else's setup, and he'll survive it — as long as you don't let him sit alone in the dark with it. That's the real technology in this house. Not the processors. Not the projectors. The timing. Forty years I've been waiting to deliver this punchline, and he laughed. He

laughed. Now comes the hard part — because a joke's not finished when the audience laughs. It's finished when they tell it to somebody else. And Nancy, sweetheart... have WE got a story for you.

END OF BOOK FOUR

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Derek Devon is the pen name of a first-time novelist who spent a long career in the corporate world before deciding the stories rattling around his head deserved better than PowerPoint. He is the author of the seventeen-book science fiction series *The Last Axiom* and the debut novel *A Letter Guide for Rebecca*.

Living With the Ghost of Sam is his love letter to the golden age of stand-up comedy, to old houses with opinions, and to everyone who ever lost someone and kept the conversation going.

He lives in Florida, where the thunder is frequent and, he insists, occasionally well-timed.

ALSO BY DEREK DEVON

The Last Axiom (Books 1–15)

A Letter Guide for Rebecca